1,420 seats for corporators, 199 for nagar palika parishad chairpersons, 5,327 for nagar palika parishad members, 544 for nagar panchayat chairpersons and 7,178 seats for nagar panchayat members are up for grabs.

The BJP has been the party to beat in the past two local body elections, consistently dominating the mayoral seats (it won 14 out of 16 in 2017), but is leaving no stone unturned to ensure, as a senior BJP functionary put it, a "clean sweep". To shore up support for its candidates, the party has deputed 30 ministers who will be fanning out across 37 districts to accompany the candidates during the filing of nomination papers.

Chief minister Yogi Adityanath launched his campaign for the party candidates on April 24 from Saharanpur in western UP. He's also the face of the campaign, with party posters not just tom-tomming the Yogi government's initiatives but also his slogan in the assembly: "*Mafia raj ko khatam kar diya...Mitti mein mila diya...* (We have ended the mafia raj, ground it to dust)". The UP police are also backing this claim. On April 14, special DGP (law and order) Prashant Kumar trotted out the numbers for reporters—since March 2017, when Yogi took over, 183 alleged criminals have been gunned down and 5,046 injured in encounters, and over 23,300 have been arrested.

At the same time, Yogi has much bigger stakes in these local body polls. Before the Lok Sabha polls, this is his last chance to showcase himself as the second most popular mass leader in the BJP after Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Hence Yogi's declaration in Gorakhpur that the "nagar nigam election is my responsibility".

This time, the party has decided not to give tickets to the family members of cabinet ministers, MPs and MLAs. Apparently, a few senior state BJP leaders (including some cabinet ministers) had been trying to get tickets for their wives in the seats reserved for women. The party leadership, though, has decided that local leaders and party cadre need to feel that they are valued and tickets in the local body polls would instil a sense of involvement. Following this vein of thought, the party has gone in for a number of fresh faces. In fact, of the 14 BJP mayors in office currently, only three—in Bareilly, Kanpur and Moradabad—are getting a second shot at power.

Meanwhile, the SP seems confident and will be hoping to make some amends for its 2017 show, when it had drawn a blank in the urban bodies. SP president Akhilesh Yadav has resolved his dispute with uncle Shivpal Yadav and has prepared a joint strategy with ally Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). Both parties have been trying to expand their base since the 2022 assembly election loss, the SP looking beyond its Muslim-Yadav core constituencies to win over Dalits and other OBCs and the RLD training its sights past the Jats and Muslims in their corral.

Akhilesh and RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary are working with Azad Samaj Party chief Chandrashekhar Azad (of Bhim Army fame). Even if the latter's base among the Dalits of western UP is unproven, it still constitutes a move to broad-base the Samajwadi-RLD footprint. Earlier this month, Akhilesh unveiled a statue of Dalit leader (and BSP founder) Kanshi Ram in Rae Bareli and attended an event to commemorate the birth anniversary of B.R. Ambedkar in Madhya Pradesh's Mhow. The SP has also backed the demand for a caste census, an issue that has been picking up traction of late. The SP hopes to get some Dalit support in the districts, but fears the post-Atiq murder polarisation will work to its disadvantage, especially in urban areas—and has consequently been muted on the subject.

The other big party in the mix, the BSP, has decided to go the other way, whipping out the minority card prominently by fielding Muslims in 11 of the 17 mayoral seats. If it succeeds in wooing the Muslims back to cohabit with its core Dalit vote bank, it could spoil the equation for the SP, which has been positioning itself as the main rival of the BJP. The Congress, a shadow of its former self in UP, has focused on giving tickets to party cadre, the idea being to boost their morale before the big battle in 2024. Party sources say UP in-charge Priyanka Gandhi may not even campaign in these polls.

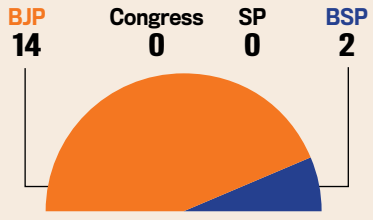
Regardless of the results this time, the moves on the chessboard speak of an evolution in political strategies that could have longer-term implications. ■

SAFFRON FORT

The BJP has been invincible in the UP urban body polls

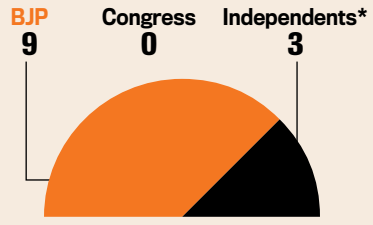
2017 MAYOR SEAT RESULTS

TOTAL SEAT 16



2012 MAYOR POLLS RESULTS

TOTAL SEAT 12



**SP had backed 2 winning candidates while the BSP had backed one*

THE MAFIA CRACKDOWN WILL BE A BIG PLANK FOR THE BJP IN THE LOCAL BODY POLLS, WHILE THE OPPOSITION SP-RLD AND BSP HAVE MADE SOME INTERESTING TACTICAL SHIFTS THAT COULD HAVE LONG-TERM IMPLICATIONS